

How do you make sure a rocket burns the right amount of fuel at the right time to place astronauts safely into Earth's orbit? How do you place a spacecraft in orbit around the moon without crashing into it? These were some of the questions that Katherine Johnson helped to answer. She skipped grades in school and earned her first college degree in math at just 18—the age when most people start college.

At this time in the US, there were two big things that made it more difficult for Katherine to succeed: she was a woman and she was Black. Even so, in 1953, she got a job as a mathematician for the US government department that later became NASA (National Aeronautics and Space Administration).

Katherine later worked on satellites, and on the Space Shuttle program.



KATHERINE JOHNSON

American mathematician • 1918–2020